

HVAC Replacement Buyer's Guide

Sizing questions, efficiency, ductwork, accessories and
quote comparison

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Plan first. Price second.

This 12-page field guide is designed to be used beside HomeCostEngine calculators, measurements, product selections and contractor proposals. It does not try to replace a site inspection or local professional. Instead, it helps you make assumptions visible so quotes become easier to understand and compare.

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Use this guide for planning and education only. Verify final pricing, code, permits, suitability and scope with qualified local professionals.

Start with load and comfort

Use home size only as a starting point and ask how the contractor evaluates climate, insulation, windows and air leakage. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for replacing equipment solely by the old nameplate size. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Ask what sizing method and assumptions support the recommendation.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

What is the one assumption on this page that could change your price or contractor scope? Write it down before moving to the next chapter.

Compare system types

Understand central AC, heat pumps, furnaces and ductless systems in the context of the home. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for comparing equipment prices without matching heating and cooling scope. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Define the system functions each proposal must provide.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Evaluate efficiency carefully

Compare efficiency ratings with installed cost, climate and expected operating use. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for buying the highest rating without considering payback or compatibility. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Ask for a like-for-like efficiency comparison and assumptions.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Inspect ductwork and airflow

Include visible duct condition, return paths, filtration and balancing in the replacement discussion. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for installing new equipment onto known airflow problems without a plan. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Request duct repairs or exclusions in writing.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Identify electrical and condensate work

Confirm disconnects, breakers, line sets, drains, pumps, pads and controls. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for a low equipment quote that omits supporting installation work. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Create a complete accessory and infrastructure list.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Compare warranties and commissioning

Separate parts, labor and installer workmanship coverage and ask how startup is documented. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for assuming a long parts warranty includes future labor. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Request commissioning or startup records and registration responsibilities.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Plan total ownership cost

Consider maintenance, filter costs, energy use and likely service needs beyond the purchase price. The purpose is to turn a broad project assumption into something you can measure, price or confirm in writing. Keep homeowner decisions separate from items that require a site inspection, product specification or local professional review.

Watch for using a simple equipment price as the full ownership comparison. If a proposal or plan leaves this point unclear, do not bury it inside the total. Record the assumption, ask who is responsible, and decide whether it belongs in fixed scope, an allowance, a unit price or contingency.

Action plan

- Keep a replacement and maintenance record after installation.
- Write the supporting measurement, quote line or product selection next to this decision.
- Update the working budget as soon as the assumption changes.

FIELD NOTE

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Project checklist

Resolve or document each item before you approve the final scope or purchase decision.

- Sizing method discussed
- System functions matched
- Efficiency assumptions
- Duct and airflow scope
- Electrical and drain scope
- Warranty details
- Startup documentation

CHECKPOINT

Any unchecked item is not automatically a problem. It is a prompt to clarify responsibility, price or assumptions in writing before money is committed.

WORKING DOCUMENT

Budget worksheet

Keep planned amounts, actual quotes and notes together. Do not hide allowances or contingency inside one total.

Equipment	Planned: \$ _____
Labor	Planned: \$ _____
Ductwork	Planned: \$ _____
Electrical	Planned: \$ _____
Line set and drains	Planned: \$ _____
Controls and accessories	Planned: \$ _____
Permits	Planned: \$ _____
Contingency	Planned: \$ _____

Update this worksheet whenever a quote, selection or change order changes the project.

Next steps

You now have a practical framework for hvac planning. Move from generic assumptions to real measurements, written product selections and comparable local proposals as your project becomes more defined.

Use HomeCostEngine next

- Run the relevant free calculator at homecostengine.com.
- Compare contractor proposals with matching scope and allowances.
- Keep a separate contingency instead of hiding uncertainty inside fixed costs.
- Save this guide with your quotes, selections and final project records.

HOME COST PLANNING - CLEARER ASSUMPTIONS - BETTER QUESTIONS

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Educational planning resource only. Always verify project-specific decisions with qualified local professionals.